



EA Value: How It Changes with Organisational Maturity

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There Is No Single Definition of Value

How do you define value when it comes to enterprise architecture?

There is no single, universally correct definition. Ask ten enterprise architects and you'll get ten different responses. Some will say it's about defining the target state. Others will argue it's about controlling technology sprawl or enforcing standards. They're all partially right, and that's the problem. Value in EA is not a fixed concept. It shifts depending on who you're speaking to, what they care about, and what the organisation actually needs at that point in time.

Ultimately, value is shaped by the organisation you are in, the people you are working with, and, most importantly, the priorities of your stakeholders.

What one CIO sees as valuable, another may ignore completely. Some will care deeply about technology risk and lifecycle. Others will only engage when you start talking about business outcomes. It means that as EAs, we have to adapt, as these are simply different starting points.

Importantly, there is one clear indicator that something isn't working. If no one sees any value in what you are doing, then you are doing the wrong thing. Enterprise architecture should not exist to satisfy a model or follow a manual. It should exist to solve problems that people in the organisation recognise and care about.

Our view is that enterprise architecture value is the ability to improve decision-making, reduce risk, optimise cost, and enable change by providing a clear understanding of how business, applications, information, and technology are connected.

However, how that value is realised in practice depends on stakeholder priorities and the maturity of the organisation.

Start With the Stakeholder, Not the Framework

In lower maturity organisations, this is where most teams go wrong. They often start with a framework, a meta-model, or a view of what "good" looks like, and then try to impose that on the organisation (for fans of The Simpsons this is very similar to Homer's car, '[Oh Brother, Where Art Thou?](#)' where Homer designs what he thinks people want, based on his needs and ends up with a monstrosity).

In reality, the starting point should be much simpler, which is to understand the needs of your primary stakeholder: the CIO.

Some stakeholders are more technology-focused. They often come from infrastructure or engineering backgrounds and think in terms of platforms, lifecycle, cost, and risk. Their view of the world tends to move from technology up into the business. They are concerned with legacy estates, upgrades, and stability, and they may have little interest in what they see as purely abstract constructs like business capabilities.

Others are more business-focused. They anchor on outcomes, capabilities, and how the organisation operates. For them, applications become the key focus – they want to understand how systems support the business, where duplication exists, and how effectively technology enables delivery.

The only reliable way to understand what matters to your stakeholders is to speak to them. Incorrect assumptions are where most EA efforts lose relevance before they even begin.

Understanding Value in Practice

Ultimately, enterprise architecture is trying to answer three simple questions: where are we today, where do we want to be, and how do we get to where we want to be?

The problem is that many low maturity EA teams jump straight to the second question. They want strategy, target states, and multi-year roadmaps. But in most cases, those things have limited impact until there is a clear understanding of the current state.

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People are rarely interested in the future if they don't trust the view of the present. There is also a practical reality that often gets overlooked. With CIO tenure typically [around 3–5 years](#), long-term architectural strategies often need to deliver value within shorter timeframes. Priorities shift, strategies evolve, and long-term plans are frequently interrupted. That means enterprise architecture cannot rely solely on distant outcomes to demonstrate value.

So, part of the EA role is to help stakeholders succeed in the short term as well as the long term. That means delivering useful, visible outcomes early, while quietly building the foundations for more strategic work later. Do some longer term work but don't let it dominate over short-term value delivery. The balance between those two is where effective EA teams differentiate themselves.

How Maturity Shapes Value

The value and benefits of enterprise architecture change significantly depending on organisational maturity. What matters at the start when you are building credibility, is very different from what matters later when you have strong credibility.

Low Maturity: Building Credibility

At low maturity, the primary objective is not creating perfection, it is establishing credibility. Enterprise architecture is often unproven, and stakeholders are looking for evidence that it can deliver something useful.

This is not the time to paint long-term, idealised pictures. It is the time to focus on real, tangible, short term needs, guided by at least some view of where things are heading. Most organisations don't need a perfect target state on day one. They need clarity on what's in front of them right now. That usually starts with very practical issues, such as disconnected application lists, poorly understood legacy technology, duplication across the estate, and limited visibility into how systems actually support the business. Again, ask the stakeholder.

Improving visibility is usually the first meaningful step to building credibility. Creating a usable baseline, even if it is incomplete, allows conversations to move forward. At the same time, it is important to establish simple ways of keeping that information up to date, without which, even the best initial effort will quickly lose value.

Governance at this stage should be minimal, as it will tend to slow things down and you are likely to see resistance from change teams. The goal is to show that EA can help, not to enforce control.

Mid Maturity: Supporting Better Decisions

As maturity increases, the focus should shift. By now, there is usually some level of engagement and trust, along with a group of stakeholders who see the benefit of what has been created.

Now the emphasis moves to using the information that has been captured. Impact analysis, dependency mapping, and supporting change initiatives become the focus, with the aim of improving decision-making, reducing uncertainty, and helping delivery teams understand the implications of their actions.

This is where enterprise architecture starts to move from documentation to something more operational. It becomes a tool for answering real questions, rather than simply describing the estate.

Governance may start to become more necessary, but it should still be light-touch. The most effective teams at this stage focus on enabling better outcomes rather than enforcing compliance.

High Maturity: Enabling Strategy and Influence

At high maturity, enterprise architecture becomes embedded in how the organisation operates. Teams no longer need to be convinced to engage; they should come to the enterprise architecture with questions because they know the value is there.

The role of EA shifts again. It becomes more about using the enterprise architecture to guide decisions. Supporting strategic planning, scenario modelling, and shaping change initiatives become the primary focus.

One of the most important characteristics at this level is how governance is handled. The most successful organisations do not rely on heavy, centralised control. Instead, they create an environment where people are encouraged to self-govern. Enterprise architecture becomes accessible, understandable, and part of everyday thinking: see our previous blogs on [‘Everyone’s an architect’](#).

At this point, EA is no longer a separate function. It is simply a key part of how the organisation understands itself and makes decisions.

Do You Need an EA Tool?

The answer, once again, depends on where you are.

You can rely on knowledge held in people's heads, but that only goes so far. People only know what they know, and that knowledge is often fragmented, inconsistent and difficult to access when you actually need it. A tool helps bring that knowledge together and make it usable.

At low maturity, simple tools can be enough. If you are working with basic lists and trying to establish a baseline, spreadsheets may be perfectly adequate. The important thing is that the information exists and can be shared.

However, as complexity increases, the limitations of simple tools quickly become apparent. Knowledge remains scattered, relationships between elements become harder to track, and the organisation becomes increasingly dependent on a small number of individuals.

At that point, the risk of knowledge gaps grows. Questions such as “who is impacted if that server goes down?” become difficult to answer with confidence. That is when the need for something more structured becomes clear.

The foundational enterprise architecture information is fundamentally about relationships, such as how applications support processes, how processes realise capabilities, and how technology underpins it all. It is that information and the relationships within it that gives us additional insight to make better decisions. Managing those relationships with simple tools becomes increasingly difficult as the estate grows.

This is where more structured approaches become necessary. If you want to codify knowledge, manage complexity, and enable more advanced analysis, particularly with AI, then [the structure of your data becomes critical](#). Spreadsheets struggle to support this because they are not designed to represent interconnected elements.

Value Is Earned Over Time

Enterprise architecture does not deliver value because it follows a framework or uses a particular tool. It delivers value because it solves problems that matter at the time they arise.

That value evolves as the organisation matures. What starts as visibility becomes insight. Insight becomes influence. Influence becomes part of how decisions are made.

The key is not to aim too big too early but to start small, deliver something useful, and build from there.

Value in enterprise architecture is not something you define once. It is something you demonstrate and earn, continuously.

Key Takeaways for Enterprise Architecture Value

- Value depends on organisational maturity and stakeholder priorities
- Early-stage EA delivers visibility and credibility
- Mid-stage EA improves decision-making and delivery speed
- Mature EA enables strategy and organisational alignment
- Tools become critical as complexity and relationships increase
- Enterprise architecture value evolves continuously with maturity

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